Batting a Thousand

(From Fat Girls and Lawn Chairs)

By Cheryl Peck

INTRODUCTION

It isn't easy being a bat. With Dracula, a few cases of rabies, their pointy teeth, and the fact that they hang upside down to sleep, bats inspire fear in many people. Forget all those stories about bats being blind, becoming entangled in hair, and transmitting diseases to humans and animals. Myths about bats abound, but the facts about these animals are actually far more interesting. For example, did you know that a single little brown bat can catch more than 1,000 mosquitoes in just one hour. Or that North America's common little brown bat has the world's longest lifespan for a mammal of its size, sometimes living more than 32 years. Of course expanding your knowledge base about bats becomes much less important when you find one inside your house! Batting a Thousand from Fat Girls and Lawn Chairs by Cheryl Peck.

I was sitting at the keyboard and Babycakes was sitting on my shoulder, half-asleep (both the cat and the shoulder) when an utterly silent shadow rippled across the room. I thought, *There's a bird in this room.*

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Something was amiss, I could tell by the repetitive lashing of my left ear by the cat's tail.

A large bird, I reflected, reviewing my memory, *black and swooping-probably a rogue turkey vulture.*

But I sat at my keyboard and the cat sat on my shoulder, and for the longest time nothing happened.

It's all your imagination, I reproved myself. *Perhaps it was merely a giant moth.* And at that exact moment, an utterly silent shadow swooped across the room.

The cat bolted off my shoulder, taking along small bits of my skin, and huddled down on the floor where he made himself into a small gold rug with big accusing gold eyes, which he trained on me, as if to say, *What have you done now?* Circling my light like a drunken glider was a bat. I know very little about bats now and I knew even less then.

This bat was small and brown. (This observation is unusually precise. Experts in batology would have called it a small brown bat. I did not know this, at the time.)

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When I stood up, the circle the bat was flying around my light became more elliptical, as if something large and horrifying had wandered into its radar. I looked around, but I never did see what it was.

I spoke to the bat. I said, "Go away."

I walked over to the window, raised the screen, and posed, not altogether unlike Vanna White. "Here would be a good place to go," I directed.

The bat switched the tilt of his ellipse from one side of the room to the other. Beyond that I could see no real change in his behavior. He swept past me once, dangerously close to my hair, which I interpreted as an act of aggression.

I may have shrieked. (Once. It was one of those girl-instinct things that some times gets the better of me.)

I went back to the other side of the room, beside the keyboard, and waited.

The bat stopped circling. He had thrown up some subsonic invisibility ray to disguise his whereabouts. I

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looked expectantly at the cat. The cat looked disgusted and bathed a wild hair.

I thought to myself, *leave the screen open, close the computer room door and go to bed--when you wake up* in *the morning, the bat will be gone.*

Or, thirty thousand of his closest friends will be partying in *the computer room. There will be stale beer and* com *nuts all over the keyboard, small drunken aviators will be hanging upside down from the curtain* rods . . .

Bats are good, my conscience lectured me, *don't do anything to hurt this innocent little bat.*

So I closed the screen, closed the door and snuck myself and the cat out of the computer room and went to bed.

In the morning the bat did seem to have vacated the premises.

The following night I was sitting at the keyboard with a sleeping cat on my sleeping shoulder when an utterly silent shadow rippled across the room.

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The cat lunged off my shoulder, taking most of my right arm with him, and hid under the desk.

"That's it," I said, "I'm done-get out of my house."

And I went for the tennis racket.

(We will take a moment from our narrative to allow all of my personal friends to finish turning to one another and murmuring, "Cheryl Peck owns a tennis racket?" I do. I stole it from the Wee One because I could see no reason why my little sister should own a tennis racket when I didn't. I don't play tennis, but then again, I might. Besides, she quit playing right after that.)

My plan was simple, but well organized: I would swing the tennis racket, knocking the bat out of the air into a small trash can I held in the other hand. I would then slam the tennis racket over the top of the can, constructing a makeshift jail long enough to carry my prisoner downstairs and outside to freedom, where he would gratefully flyaway.

The cat at my heels was just insurance. Somewhat wimpy insurance, judging from the cowering crouch, but I assured myself that once the bat had stopped, it would

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look to the cat like what it looked to me-a flying mouse. The cat has never been out of the house and mice have never been in the house, but I trusted fervently that instincts would burst into play at the appropriate moment.

I swung my tennis racket. I caught a solid draft of sheer air, nearly knocking myself off balance, while the bat circled around and swooped just over my head.

I waited, muscles tensed for action, instincts honed, my heart pounding with the lust to kill: I swung again, nearly decapitated the cat, drove my own knee forcefully into the trash can as I stumbled forward, and I cursed myself for every tennis lesson I never took.

On the third swing I knocked the bat out of the air onto the ground, where it twitched twice, attached itself to the grid of my tennis racket and began crawling up the handle. Swiftly, possibly shrieking (for only the second time in my life), I scraped the offending creature into the trash can, where it hung upside down, still glued to the racket. All three of us thundered down the stairs to the front door where a passionate discussion ensued

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concerning who can go outside and who cannot. In the meantime, the bat was shaking his battered little head and beginning to stir. The cat would not give up: he would go outside and oversee the release of the bat, or no one would go outside. He glued his back to the door, his paws spread, nailed against the door like a tiny hairy Jesus figure.

I explained that if he had been a proper cat, he would have caught the bat, eaten it and I would never have had to deal with the situation at all.

He spoke to me about the lure of the wild life, the faint perfume of wanton females in the wind, the sheer testosterone of hunting and killing his own food.

I set the trash can on the floor, its inmate twitching erratically against its mesh caging.

"Okay, so perhaps not," huffed the cat. He flicked his tail at me and stalked with great dignity into the kitchen.

I carried the bat outside and released him. Or, at least I tried. I waved him toward freedom.

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The bat remained glued to the tennis racket. I waited for the scent of freedom to call him. He wrapped his wings around his head and pretended to be dead.

To the bat I said, "Give me back my tennis racket." For, having used this racket to play one game of tennis in the thirteen years it had hung in my basement stairway, I was loath to leave it outside, unattended, in the wind and the weather to warp and perhaps be destroyed.

"Get off, get off," I wailed, and began dancing the hopping whines of the terminally mature.

The cat poked his head through the curtains to see what I was up to, and then went away.

I scraped the bat off my tennis racket against the stone flower box on my front porch not unlike the way one would remove peanut butter from a knife blade.

"Die there, then," I tossed as my parting shot.

The bat, batted and bewildered, cat-threatened and smashed and trashed-and, very likely, hungry-gathered his tiny bat wings up, shook them off, staggered a few steps down the flower box, then

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gathered himself together and flew unsteadily off into the sunset.

I suspect he warned his friends. *Fear the mighty [dyke: replace with chick] that lives in that house,* he told them all. *That woman has a shriek that will foul up your radar for days.*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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